Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom

The big idea

This extract from **Nelson Mandela's autobiography, *Long Walk to Freedom*,** describes the day he became the **first Black President of South Africa** and his reflections on what freedom really means. It teaches that courage, sacrifice and love can triumph over hatred.

KEY FACTS

- **Date:** 10 May 1994 — inauguration at the **Union Buildings in Pretoria**.
- South Africa's **first democratic, non-racial government**.
- Two Deputy Presidents: **Thabo Mbeki** and **F.W. de Klerk**.
- Ended **apartheid**, a system of racial discrimination and segregation.

Summary

- **The inauguration:** Leaders and dignitaries from more than 140 countries gathered. Mandela took the oath and pledged to liberate the people from bondage, poverty, deprivation and discrimination. He said: never again shall this beautiful land experience the oppression of one by another.
- **The display of the military:** Jets, helicopters and troop carriers flew in formation over the Union Buildings. The highest generals saluted Mandela and pledged loyalty — the same forces that a few years earlier would have arrested him. This showed the army's loyalty to democracy.
- **Two anthems:** Whites sang **"Nkosi Sikelel' iAfrika"** and Blacks sang **"Die Stem"**, the old anthem of the Republic — a symbol of unity, though neither group yet knew the other's song by heart.

- **The cost of freedom:** Mandela recalls that apartheid created one of the most extensive and inhumane societies the world had known. He says the **depths of oppression created heights of character** — leaders like **Oliver Tambo, Walter Sisulu, Chief Luthuli, Yusuf Dadoo, Bram Fischer and Robert Sobukwe**. A country's greatest wealth is its people.
- **Courage:** He learnt that courage was not the absence of fear but **the triumph over it**. The brave man is not one who does not feel afraid, but one who conquers that fear.
- **Love over hate:** No one is born hating another person because of the colour of his skin. If people can learn to hate, they can be taught to love, for love comes more naturally to the human heart.

Twin obligations

Every man has **twin obligations**:

1. to his **family** — parents, wife and children;
2. to his **people, community and country**.
   In a normal society a man can fulfil both. In apartheid South Africa, a Black man who tried to live as a human being was punished and isolated. Mandela was forced to choose his people over his family, which cost him time with his wife and children.

Mandela's changing idea of freedom

Stage	What freedom meant
As a boy	Freedom to run in the fields, swim in the stream, roast mealies, ride bulls — he thought he was born free.
As a young man	"Transitory freedoms": staying out at night, reading what he liked, going where he chose — and then basic freedoms like earning a living, marrying and having a family.

Stage	What freedom meant
Later	He saw that his brothers and sisters were not free. The hunger for his own freedom became the **greater hunger for the freedom of his people**. He joined the **African National Congress**.

OPPRESSOR AND OPPRESSED

Mandela says **the oppressor must be liberated just as surely as the oppressed**. A man who takes away another's freedom is a prisoner of hatred, locked behind bars of prejudice. Both are robbed of their humanity.

WHO SANG WHICH ANTHEM

Do not swap them: the **whites** sang Nkosi Sikelel' iAfrika and the **blacks** sang Die Stem — each singing the other's anthem was the symbol of unity.

Message and value points

- Freedom is indivisible; no one is free while others are in chains.
- Courage means conquering fear; love is more natural than hate.
- Great leaders sacrifice personal happiness for the common good.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Twin obligations; meaning of "the depths of oppression create heights of character"; why Mandela calls the oppressor a prisoner; how his idea of freedom changed. Quote one short phrase and explain it in your own words.

Quick recap

- 10 May 1994, Union Buildings, Pretoria; first non-racial government.
- Deputy Presidents: Thabo Mbeki and F.W. de Klerk.

- Courage = triumph over fear; love comes more naturally than hate.
- Twin obligations: family and people/country.
- Freedom: boyhood illusion → personal freedom → freedom of all his people.

Practice questions

1. Nelson Mandela was sworn in as President on

   (a) 26 January 1994 (b) 10 May 1994 (c) 15 August 1994 (d) 10 May 1990

2. Who were the two Deputy Presidents sworn in?

   (a) Oliver Tambo and Walter Sisulu (b) Chief Luthuli and Bram Fischer (c) Thabo Mbeki and F.W. de Klerk (d) Yusuf Dadoo and Robert Sobukwe

3. According to Mandela, courage is

   (a) the absence of fear (b) the triumph over fear (c) the use of weapons (d) never feeling pain

4. What did the military display at the ceremony show?

   (a) That South Africa was preparing for war (b) That the army opposed democracy (c) That the generals wanted power (d) The loyalty of the defence forces to democracy

5. What does Mandela say "the depths of oppression" created?

   (a) Heights of character (b) Hatred among people (c) Poverty and hunger (d) Weak leaders

6. Mandela's "twin obligations" were to

   (a) God and the government (b) himself and his friends (c) the army and the people (d) his family and his people and country

7. As a boy, Mandela thought freedom was

   (a) the right to vote (b) a good education (c) the freedom to run in the fields and swim in the stream (d) the end of apartheid

8. Why does Mandela say that the oppressor and the oppressed both need to be freed?

9. How did Mandela's understanding of freedom change with age?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. a 6. d 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes